

LITHOBATES SPHENOCEPHALUS (Southern Leopard Frog).

DIET. *Lithobates sphenoccephalus* is a medium-sized ranid frog commonly found in wetland and upland habitats throughout the southeastern United States (Krysko et al. 2019. *Amphibians and Reptiles of Florida*, University of Florida Press, Gainesville, Florida. 706 pp.). The species feeds primarily on invertebrates but is known to be a voracious feeder that opportunistically attempts to consume any small moving organism it encounters. While predation of vertebrate species by *L. sphenoccephalus* is rarely observed, one study found remains of vertebrates (primarily the mosquitofish *Gambusia affinis* but also several additional fish, frog, and salamander species) in the stomachs of 37 out of 443 individuals sampled (Kilby 1945. *Quart. J. Florida Acad. Sci.* 8:71–104). *Lithobates sphenoccephalus* has also been observed preying upon the non-native *Eleutherodactylus planirostris* (Greenhouse Frog) (Baakliny and Kutok 2023. *Herpetol. Rev.* 54:272), as well as cannibalizing its own species (DR Jackson, pers. comm.). Although consumption of reptilian and mammalian vertebrates by *L. sphenoccephalus* seems to occur considerably less frequently, a few reports do exist, including one *L. sphenoccephalus* that was photographed swallowing a *Lasiurus seminolus* (Seminole Bat) (Carr 1940. *Univ. Florida Biol. Sci. Ser.* 3:1–118) and a *L.*

sphenoccephalus that was found DOR with a *Scincella lateralis* (Little Brown Skink) in its stomach (Farr and Forstner 2014. *Herpetol. Rev.* 45:682).

At 2111 h on 20 May 2025, I observed an adult *L. sphenoccephalus* consuming a non-native *Hemidactylus mabouia* (Tropical House Gecko) along the edge of Lake Jackson in Osceola County, Florida, USA (27.91095°N, 81.14981°W; WGS 84). Only the anterior third of the *H. mabouia* remained visible outside the mouth of the *L. sphenoccephalus* (Fig. 1), with the mouth of the *H. mabouia* clamped firmly over the anterior right foot of the *L. sphenoccephalus* (a presumed anti-predation behavior). When accidentally startled, the *L. sphenoccephalus* made a single escape hop and, while doing so, pushed the rest of the *H. mabouia* into its mouth. Because the *H. mabouia* did not relinquish its bite during this process, the *L. sphenoccephalus* landed with its own foot inside its mouth. At this point, I temporarily retreated to avoid further disturbing the predation event. When I returned ca. five minutes later, the *L. sphenoccephalus* was still present and had freed its forelimb from the grasp of the *H. mabouia*. The *H. mabouia* was not visible and is presumed to have been successfully predated, although it is possible the *H. mabouia* may have escaped if the *L. sphenoccephalus* removed its limb from its mouth with the *H. mabouia* still attached. To my knowledge, this observation constitutes the first record of a predation attempt of *L. sphenoccephalus* upon any *Hemidactylus* sp. gecko, as well as only the second record of *L. sphenoccephalus* preying upon any lizard.

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FIG. 1. *Lithobates sphenoccephalus* consuming an adult *Hemidactylus mabouia*.